

Reading for Understanding

1. What caused the ‘universal start’ in the boys? (Paragraph 1) The "universal start" (a collective jump or flinch) was caused by Squeers hitting his desk with a "tremendous" blow. This was his favorite way of intimidating the students and demanding immediate silence.

2. Why do you think Nicholas Nickleby had a ‘very curious expression’ on his face? (Paragraph 1) Nicholas likely had this expression because he was reaching his breaking point. He was feeling a mix of suppressed anger, disgust at Squeers' cruelty, and the beginning of a firm resolution to finally intervene and stop the abuse.

3. How did the boys feel when they were forced to witness Squeers dragging Smike into the room? (Paragraph 2) The boys felt a combination of **pity, indignation (outrage), and fear**. The text notes they moved "uneasily" and the boldest among them exchanged looks that showed they felt the treatment was unjust, even though they were too afraid to speak out.

4. What did Smike mean when he said ‘Spare me, sir!’? What did Squeers mean when he said ‘I’ll flog you within an inch of your life, and spare you that.’? (Paragraph 2)

- **Smike:** He was begging for mercy, asking Squeers not to beat or hurt him.
- **Squeers:** He used a cruel play on words. He meant he would beat Smike until he was almost dead (within an inch of his life), but he would **not** "spare" him (give him) the mercy he was asking for.

5. Give two examples from Paragraph 2 of Squeers’ cruelty.

- He dragged Smike into the room by the collar (or the rags of his jacket) like an object.
- He twisted Smike’s arm two or three times to cause him pain before even starting the formal punishment.

6. Explain the ways in which Nicholas shows courage in Paragraph 3. Nicholas shows courage by:

- **Speaking up:** He shouts "Stop!" in a loud, commanding voice that shocks the room.
- **Physical presence:** He steps forward to confront Squeers face-to-face.
- **Defiance:** He openly tells Squeers, "I will prevent it," directly challenging the authority of a man who everyone else is terrified of.

7. Why was Squeers robbed of speech for a moment in Paragraph 3? Squeers was "aghast and stupefied." He was so shocked that someone—especially his own assistant (the usher)—had the "boldness" to interfere with him that he literally could not find the words to respond.

8. In Paragraph 3 explain in your own words what drove Nicholas to attack Squeers? Nicholas was driven by a righteous fury. Seeing the helpless Smike screaming in pain under the first lash of the whip made Nicholas’s "blood rise." He could no longer stand by and watch such "dastardly" (cowardly) cruelty being practiced on a defenseless child.

9. In what way could the state of affairs in Paragraph 4 be said to be a ‘happy termination’? It is a "happy termination" (a good ending) because the bully, Squeers, was finally defeated and left "motionless" on the ground, the immediate physical danger to the children was stopped, and Nicholas was able to leave the "foul den" of the school forever.

10. How was it that Smike was in the barn where Nicholas had taken a night’s rest? (Paragraph 5) Smike had followed Nicholas. After Nicholas left the school, Smike—having no one else in the world who had shown him kindness—trailed after him and found the same place to hide.

11. Why do you think Smike knelt before Nicholas in Paragraph 5? Smike knelt out of **gratitude and devotion**. Nicholas was the first person to ever protect him and stand up for him. By kneeling, Smike is showing his loyalty and likely pleading to stay with Nicholas so he is not left alone again.

12. Explain the similarities and differences between the characters of Squeers and Nicholas. Squeers and Nicholas are both men in positions of authority at the school, and both are shown to be capable of physical strength and force. However, their characters are opposites. **Squeers** is a cowardly, "diabolical" bully who uses his power to inflict pain on the weak for his own satisfaction. He is described as "brutish" and "savage." In contrast, **Nicholas** is a man of high moral character and "indignation." He uses his strength only to protect those who cannot protect themselves. While Squeers rules through fear and violence, Nicholas acts out of justice and compassion.